

## FESTIVALS &amp; CELEBRATIONS

“When communities gather, culture becomes visible.”

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Celebration is one of the ways a community remembers that life is more than its difficulties. A festival can bring families together. A religious holiday can turn neighbours into guests. A sporting event can gather generations around the same field. A spring celebration can reconnect people with a landscape. And sometimes, a modern festival becomes a new way of expressing an older sense of community. For the Orakzai, celebration exists at several levels: faith, family, hospitality, community, season, sport, and cultural identity. But not every celebration has the same history. Some are religious. Some are regional. Some are modern. Some survive mainly through family memory.

## COMMUNITY GATHERING

“Faith, Family, Sport, and Season”



“A central valley gathering uniting faith, sport, and tradition.”

WHAT IS A FESTIVAL?

Festivals are multifaceted social phenomena. They can be religious obligations, seasonal markers, athletic competitions, or contemporary cultural programs. Understanding an Orakzai festival requires looking at its underlying motivations and historical roots.

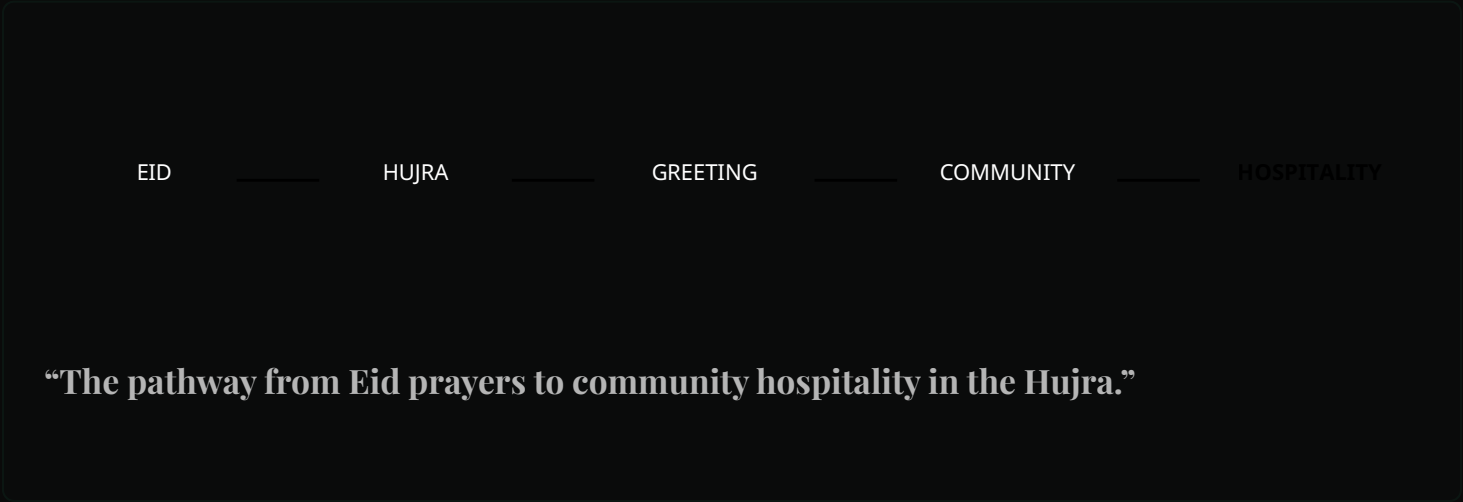


RELIGIOUS FESTIVALS: EID-UL-FITR & EID-UL-ADHA

The primary religious celebrations for Orakzai families, as for Muslims worldwide, are **Eid-ul-Fitr** (marking the conclusion of Ramadan) and **Eid-ul-Adha** (associated with the pilgrimage and the commemoration of Prophet Ibrahim's obedience). These are fundamental Islamic observances combined with Pashtun community practices and local family customs.



During religious holidays, the Pashtun **Hujra** (community guesthouse) takes on an active social role. Ethnographic scholarship documents how men gather in the Hujra after Eid prayers to exchange greetings, drink tea, and welcome visitors. This blends Islamic fellowship with traditional Pashtun hospitality (**Melmastia**).<sup>3</sup>



ORAKZAI SPRING FESTIVAL (JASHAN-E-BAHARAN 2024)

A notable documented event in recent years is the three-day **Spring Mela / Jashan-e-Baharan** organized in the Orakzai District (at Kharasha-Khwa Storikhel) in June 2024. Sponsored with involvement from local administration and cultural authorities, this festival featured traditional sports (wrestling, kabaddi, stone lifting, tug of war), modern sporting events (jeep races, motorcycle races, paragliding, cricket, football, volleyball), horse and camel performances, and cultural food and craft stalls.<sup>14</sup>

**CRITICAL DISTINCTION:** This documented event should not automatically be treated as an ancient Orakzai festival. It is evidence of contemporary cultural programming in Orakzai that brings local traditions, sport, and public celebration together.



TRADITIONAL & REGIONAL SPORTS

Traditional sports such as **Kabaddi**, **Wrestling (Pehlwani)**, and **Stone Lifting** have deep roots across Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and Pakistan. These events serve as tests of physical strength, community spectacle, and intergenerational gathering during regional fairs and festivals.<sup>1</sup>

STRENGTH & SKILL SPORTS

TRADITIONAL WRESTLING

KABADDI

STONE LIFTING

TUG OF WAR

“Core athletic events in traditional festivals.”

SPORT FUNCTIONS

SPECTACLE

COMMUNITY BONDING

INTERGENERATIONAL GATHERING

“The social role of sports in community life.”

| FESTIVAL / PRACTICE       | ORAKZAI-SPECIFIC | PASHTUN-WIDE | ISLAMIC                      | REGIONAL  | EVIDENCE            |
|---------------------------|------------------|--------------|------------------------------|-----------|---------------------|
| Eid-ul-Fitr & Eid-ul-Adha | Common Practice  | Standard     | Mandatory <div>ISLAMIC</div> | Universal | Religious Tradition |

| FESTIVAL / PRACTICE             | ORAKZAI-SPECIFIC      | PASHTUN-WIDE     | ISLAMIC | REGIONAL        | EVIDENCE           |
|---------------------------------|-----------------------|------------------|---------|-----------------|--------------------|
| Hujra Eid Gatherings            | Documented<br>PASHTUN | Core Institution | -       | Regional        | Hussain (2025) [3] |
| Jashan-e-Baharan 2024           | Documented<br>ORAKZAI | Modern Event     | -       | KP Province     | KPCTA (2024) [1]   |
| Traditional Wrestling / Kabaddi | Common<br>REGIONAL    | Popular          | -       | South Asia      | Dawn (2024) [4]    |
| Attan Dance                     | Common<br>PASHTUN     | National Dance   | -       | Afghanistan/ KP | Ahmed (1980) [2]   |

### AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

Celebration is not a luxury. It is a necessity. In a society that has endured decades of hardship, displacement, and political turmoil, the ability to gather, to play, to feast, and to celebrate is an act of resilience. When people stand shoulder-to-shoulder at an Eid gathering in a village hujra, when generations cheer for a kabaddi match or a stone-lifting contest at a spring mela, or when families share tea under the mountain sky, they are affirming that life continues. Festivals change over time. Old rituals evolve, new sports are introduced, and official programs replace spontaneous gatherings. But the underlying human need remains identical: to be together, to share joy, and to pass the warmth of community to the next generation.

“WHEN COMMUNITIES GATHER, CULTURE BECOMES VISIBLE.”

### AUTHOR'S SYNTHESIS